

Psalms 120

Deliver Me from Lying Lips

In my distress I cried unto the Lord, and he heard me... Deliver my soul, O Lord, from lying lips

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *In my distress I cried unto the LORD, and he heard me.*
- 2 *Deliver my soul, O LORD, from lying lips, and from a deceitful tongue.*
- 3 *What shall be given unto thee? or what shall be done unto thee, thou false tongue?*
- 4 *Sharp arrows of the mighty, with coals of juniper.*
- 5 *Woe is me, that I sojourn in Mesech, that I dwell in the tents of Kedar!*
- 6 *My soul hath long dwelt with him that hateth peace.*
- 7 *I am for peace: but when I speak, they are for war.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 120 opens the Songs of Ascents, the collection pilgrims sang while climbing toward Jerusalem for the great feasts, and it begins, fittingly, with the very trouble that makes a journey toward God's presence feel necessary in the first place: prolonged exposure to deceit and hostility. The psalmist names Mesech and Kedar—distant, warlike regions—not necessarily as literal geography but as a way of describing a felt sense of exile among people fundamentally unlike himself. Henry reads the psalm as the natural starting point for the whole ascent: before pilgrims sing of help, joy, or peace, they must first name the specific pain of living among those who love strife.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens with testimony rather than raw complaint: in his distress the psalmist cried to the Lord, and was heard. That answered prayer becomes the basis for a specific request repeated for emphasis—deliver my soul from lying lips, from a deceitful tongue—naming verbal treachery as the precise trouble at hand.

Verse 3-4

A pointed question follows, addressed to the deceitful tongue itself: what shall be given, or done, to it? The answer arrives in violent, fitting imagery—sharp arrows of the mighty, together with burning coals of juniper, a wood known for its hot, long-lasting embers—consequences as sharp and enduring as the harm caused by cutting, persistent speech.

Verse 5-7

The psalm closes in weary lament over prolonged dwelling among hostile strangers—Mesech, Kedar—too long a sojourner among people who love strife. The psalmist's own posture is stated plainly: I am for peace, but when I speak, they are for war—a lonely position sustained not by naivety but by deliberate conviction, even when it is not returned in kind.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Deceitful, cutting speech is treated here as a serious form of harm deserving specific, direct prayer to God rather than either quiet endurance or matching hostility with hostility. The psalmist's peaceable stance amid a hostile environment is not passivity; it is a costly, sustained choice made precisely because those around him have chosen otherwise.

Application for life today.

If you are currently exposed to gossip, manipulation, or deceitful speech, follow this psalm's example and name the harm specifically to God rather than letting it remain a vague, background anxiety. Notice that the psalmist's confidence rests on a prior answered prayer (v. 1)—let a past experience of God hearing you strengthen your present request. Examine your own commitment to peace, as verse 7 describes it: are you able to remain 'for peace' even when surrounded by people who are consistently 'for war'?

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific instance of deceitful or harmful speech in your life needs to be named directly to God, as the psalmist names 'lying lips' and a 'deceitful tongue' (vv. 2–3)?

2. How does remembering a past time God heard your distress (v. 1) strengthen your confidence in a present, unresolved difficulty?

3. Where is your own commitment to peace being tested by people who seem consistently 'for war' (v. 7), and what would it look like to hold that commitment anyway?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).